



Q DOES MINDFULNESS REALLY WORK?

Anatomical MRI scans have shown changes in subjects' brain gray matter concentration after they participated in an eight-week MBSR program, suggesting that MBSR affects areas of the brain involved in learning and memory processes, emotion regulation, self-awareness, and new perspective-taking. Another study showed that even brief training in mindfulness reduced fatigue and anxiety, while longer training seems to particularly improve attention and focus.

Q HOW DO I SIT COMFORTABLY FOR MEDITATION?

Sitting on a cushion, folded blanket, pillow, or bolster helps you to elevate your hips at an angle and tilt your pelvis to neutral, bringing a natural inward (lordotic) curve to your lumbar spine. Another traditional meditation posture is Hero pose (Virasana), or kneeling. If you feel any pain in your knees, you can use blocks or a bolster to elevate your hips. If neither of these positions work for you, you can also sit in a chair to meditate. Try to sit tall and forward in the chair, without leaning back. It may also help to sit on a cushion as this will tilt your pelvis forward slightly. Place your feet directly under your knees or a little ahead of them. If meditating in any of these seated positions is too uncomfortable, meditate in Savasana (see p.186).

Did you know?

EXTREME FOCUS, SUCH AS WHILE PLAYING AN INSTRUMENT, HAS BEEN CONNECTED WITH **MEDITATION**. PSYCHOLOGISTS CALL THIS A “FLOW STATE.” IN BOTH MEDITATION AND “FLOW,” YOUR **BRAIN WAVES** CHANGE FROM BETA—ASSOCIATED WITH THINKING AND CONVERSING—TO MOSTLY ALPHA AND THETA—ASSOCIATED WITH RELAXATION AND **CREATIVE PROBLEM-SOLVING**.

Q MY MIND IS SO BUSY. DOES THIS MEAN I'M NO GOOD AT MEDITATING?

No. Many people think meditating is about “stopping” thoughts, but it isn't. In the form of meditation most commonly practiced today, you simply observe your thoughts arising. It's like watching clouds pass by while remaining aware of the vast, clear blue sky in which they float. When meditating, your only task is to gently remind yourself to come back to the present in a state of observing.

Q WHY DO WE CHANT “OM?”

An elongated exhale turns on the relaxation response. One small study also found that chanting “om” deactivates parts of the emotional brain related to fear, compared to chanting “sssss,” as seen in fMRI brain imaging. This suggests that “om” may have benefits beyond the elongated exhale.